

If you thought 3.5 MB on the 6020 was too little, well, the Samsung X620 has a measly 3 MB internal memory. Pay more for less?

The Samsung X660 is somewhat better with 8 MB, while the honours once again go to LG—the S5200 has 64 MB and being MP3 capable. The Philip Xenium 9@9e has a passable 20 MB, while the L7 has 11 MB, and is the only phone in this category with expandable memory. Its microSD slot can support cards up to 1 GB.

The WAP 2.0 and xHTML-ready browsers remain standard here as well. The browsers on the X620 and X660 are fast, as is the L7's. The LG S5200 is sluggish when scrolling through Web pages. The two Samsungs can store 500 contacts with 10 fields, while the L7 holds 1,000 names with addresses and photo fields.

Better Keypads and Design?

The Samsung X620's keypad makes more noise while typing than the tones it generates. This apart, we must say the X620 is handy, and a good white backlight makes life with the X620 easy in the dark. The somewhat evolved version of the X620, the X660 is a clamshell design



LG C2500 - MP3 capability, 64 MB memory

and has a dual-display. When its top is closed, a smaller display shows the time and the caller number, you can thus choose to take the call or to ignore it: You can use the volume button to 'reject' a call. The keypad is more comfortable than the X620, and with an 8 MB memory the X660 is a better package any day. However, at an MRP of Rs 8,599, it costs Rs 1,000 more than the X620, which is priced at Rs 7,549.

The Philips Xenium 9@9e costs about Rs 1,000 more than the X620, and has an uninspiring and utilitarian look. Its dual-display works similar to the display of the X660. Adding to the retro look is the leather (could be faux-leather) covering its back panel. The keypad here is one of the best in terms of spacing; you'd have to be a bit tipsy to press a wrong key here! For a phone in this category, we would have liked a clearer display. The fonts look a bit too ragged for comfort. Though the exterior build quality creates a good first impression, the display can be a turn-off for the executives that this phone seems targeted at.

At the higher-end of this segment, at Rs 10,000, sit the LG C5200 and the Motorola L7. Now, this C5200 looks and even feels just like the Samsung D600: A coincidence or an inspiration? LG also offers Bluetooth; harping it rather proudly above its display. The number keys are a bit too small, but manageable. However, its small and cramped navigation keys can be a problem unless you have nimble fingers. The keypad could use brighter lighting to make the lettering clearer. For the record, its look-alike—the Samsung D600 has an excellent backlight. The only phone to have an expandable memory in this segment, the Motorola L7 is similar to its cousin, the L6, except for the memory slot. For the difference in price, we think it fair to expect at least a higher resolution camera if nothing else. But this wish remains just that—a wish.

Conclusion

'Can spend just a little more, but want a lot more'. A wish that is no doubt difficult to fulfill. But, with consumer reigning king, this wish it seems, has been catered to. Style, superb build quality, a nice keypad and an external memory slot took the Motorola L7 to the throne—just edging out the competition. Our only rant is that a higher resolution camera should have been included, instead of the VGA camera that it ships with.

Give or take one feature or even slightly better ergonomics and the result for the second place would have changed—that is the closeness of the battle fought. The contenders were the Nokia 6020; and the two LGs—the C2500 and the S5200 with their impressive internal memory of 64 MB. The 6020 and C2500 clock high overall scores in our tables mainly due to their competitive pricing. If you don't mind the higher price tag, you should take a serious look at the LG S2500, which has better ergonomics, a good 1.3 megapixel camera and MP3 playback. However, because of the price difference, the S2500 lost out to the LG C2500, which is the winner of the Digit Best Buy Silver award for this test.

Motorola V3i

Lifestyle Phones

Trendsetting designs have been the hallmark of many Motorola cell phones but somehow they always fell short of critical acclaim; due to shoddy implementation of great ideas. With the introduction of V3 RAZR, Motorola changed all that. Despite the radical design though, the phone did fall short in some aspects. With the V3i, Motorola has fixed most of the shortcomings that the V3 RAZR had.

The V3i sports the same metallic body but its new aggressive colour combination gives it splendid character. Inclusion of Motorola's monogram on the front accented with a blue backlight definitely makes an impact. Measuring 96 x 50 x 12.7 mm and weighing just 95 g, the V3i is still the slimmest clamshell phone.

The small external screen is now capable of 65K colour; unfortunately the resolution still remains the same at 96 x 80 pixels. Buttons on the sides of the phone allow voice recording and changing of profiles on the fly without opening the flap.

Opening the flap leads to a big 2.5-inch, 256K colour screen capable of delivering crisp and vibrant pictures—it also remains useable in daylight. Unlike keypads on other phones with raised buttons, the keypad on V3i flushes with the body. Getting used to the flat keys with short travel and blue backlight takes time, nevertheless they are comfortable.

The camera resolution has been bumped to a megapixel. Outdoor photographs come out better than indoors, and the video quality is good enough for the sensor provided on the phone. You also get quad-band support, Bluetooth, a VGA digital camera with 4x zoom, GPRS, PIM functionality, MPEG4 video playback and Java support. The V3i has 10 MB of internal memory and it can be further upgraded using the Transflash cards. Motorola has been generous enough to provide a 256 MB card with the phone. The new V3i also has out of the box support for iTunes, though the service isn't yet launched in India!

Priced at Rs 13,045, the V3i is a head turner for sure and garners attention wherever it goes. Targeted towards fashion conscious buyers the Motorola V3i is definitely worth the money if one can put up with Motorola's not so intuitive user interface.



+ Slim, fashionable and practical

- Average Camera

Rating: 3.5/5